

Quillfeather Lighthouse: a field guide

The Quillfeather Lighthouse stands on a granite spur above the northern shore of the invented island of Marrowby. The tower was finished in 1887 and is forty-one metres tall. Its builders cut the blocks from the spur itself, so the tower looks like a grey tooth growing out of the rock. The first lamp burned whale oil. In 1931 the keepers changed to paraffin, and in 1962 the light became electric. Sailors call the beam the Quill because it sweeps the water in a thin white stroke every nine seconds.

Visitors reach the lighthouse by a footpath of two hundred and twelve steps that starts at the old ferry pier. The climb takes about twenty minutes. A small museum in the oil store shows lamps, logbooks and the fog bell. The museum opens from May to September and is closed on Mondays.

The keepers of Quillfeather

The first head keeper of the Quillfeather Lighthouse was Odalys Brennmark. She arrived in 1887 with her brother and kept the light for thirty-three years. Her logbooks record every ship that passed, the wind, and the state of the lamp. The logbooks also record that she taught the children of the island to read in the lamp room on winter evenings.

After Brennmark retired in 1920, the post went to Tobiah Wrenfield, who served until the light was automated in 1989. Wrenfield kept bees on the south slope. The honey of the Quillfeather bees is still sold at the museum shop, and the label shows a small drawing of the tower.

The great storm and the fog bell

On the night of the ninth of November 1913, a storm that the islanders still call the Grey Week drove the steamer Halcyon Marsh onto the Marrowby shoals. The keepers saw the first rockets at midnight. Brennmark lit a second lamp in the gallery and rang the fog bell by hand for eleven hours so that the lifeboat from Skerry Quay could find the channel. All forty-seven passengers and crew reached the shore alive.

The fog bell weighs ninety kilograms and still hangs beside the door of the museum. Visitors may ring it once. The rope was replaced in 2004, and the brass plate under the bell lists the names of the forty-seven people who were saved.